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Performance, Safety, and Engineering Trade-offs of Rust and C++ in Nokia RAN Control-Plane Systems

Ha Vien

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Faculty of Science

University of Helsinki

Contact information

P. O. Box 68 (Pietari Kalmin katu 5)
00014 University of Helsinki,Finland

Email address: info@cs.helsinki.fi
URL: http://www.cs.helsinki.fi/

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1 Introduction

Mobile networks are moving from specialised hardware to software on ordinary servers. Functions that once ran on fixed-purpose, vertically integrated equipment are now re-implemented as programs on general-purpose machines. The Radio Access Network (RAN), long the most hardware-bound part of the stack, is part of that shift.

In 5G, the base station (gNB) is split into a central unit and one or more distributed units. The central unit is split again into control-plane and user-plane functions [1, 2]. Open-RAN pushes the same idea further: the RAN becomes virtualised, multi-vendor software linked by open interfaces [3]. The control plane that results, the gNB-CU-CP, is a large, stateful, highly concurrent program. It tracks every connected device, runs RRC signalling [4], and coordinates mobility and handovers, all within strict latency limits.

Load at a busy site is high. A single site can run thousands of connection-management and mobility procedures per second, each with a budget of a few milliseconds [5]. A deployed control plane may track millions of active devices at once. As the RAN moves to cloud-native, disaggregated deployments, the correctness, reliability, and timing of this software increasingly set the quality of the whole network. An outage or a tail-latency spike here is not a local defect. Every device the site serves is affected [6, 7].

This control-plane software is, today, written mostly in C++. The choice is a practical one: C++ offers the low-level control, mature tooling, and performance that latency-critical systems demand. But that performance comes with a well-known cost. C++ places the burden of memory and concurrency management on the programmer, and decades of experience show that this burden is routinely mishandled, producing use-after-free errors, double-frees, data races, and related defects that are expensive to find, dangerous in production, and responsible for a large share of security vulnerabilities in industry practice [8, 9]. Rust has emerged as the first mainstream systems language to promise an escape from this trade-off: memory safety and data-race freedom enforced at compile time, with performance intended to be competitive with C++ [10, 11]. Whether that promise holds for a telecom-grade, latency-critical control plane, where predictability under overload matters as much as raw speed, is not well understood.

This thesis, carried out at Nokia, addresses the question directly: it develops two functionally equivalent implementations of a representative RAN subsystem, a UE Context Management service modelled on a real Nokia gNB-CU-CP component, in modern C++ and in Rust, and compares them under a realistic synthetic signalling workload.

Three terms recur throughout. The *gNB-CU-CP* is the control-plane software this work is about. *UE Context Management (UECM)* is the specific subsystem reimplemented and measured. *Tail latency*, the p99 and p99.9 percentiles rather than the mean, is the property that, more than average speed, decides whether such a system meets its deadlines [6, 7]. Chapter 2 and Chapter 3 use them in that sense throughout.

1.1 Motivation and industrial context

Three trends make this comparison timely. The first is the cloud-native evolution of the RAN itself. Moving control-plane functions onto general-purpose servers raises, rather than lowers, the premium on software quality: the software is longer-lived, evolves continuously, runs at higher concurrency, and must meet its deadlines without the determinism that purpose-built hardware once provided. This shift is accelerated by Open-RAN disaggregation, which turns the base station into virtualised, multi-vendor software connected by open interfaces [3], so that the control plane a vendor ships increasingly competes on software-engineering quality (reliability, predictable timing, security, and the ease with which a large codebase can be evolved safely) and no longer on purpose-built hardware. In this setting a latency regression or a memory-corruption defect is not a localised bug but a network-wide reliability and security risk, and a language-selection question stops being academic and becomes a concrete engineering decision.

The second trend is that AI is moving from a tool used to tune the network into a workload the network is built to carry, and the next generation is being specified that way from the start. IMT-2030, the ITU framework for 6G, lists artificial intelligence and communication among its six usage scenarios and ubiquitous intelligence among its four design principles [12]. The architecture forming around that is AI-RAN, in which telecommunications and AI workloads are orchestrated together on shared, accelerated infrastructure, so the sites that run the radio also host distributed edge AI platforms [13]. The AI-RAN Alliance states the operational requirement directly:

one common infrastructure has to run both kinds of workload concurrently, and their service-level agreements may differ [14]. That changes what a language choice has to buy for a control plane. Its software no longer has the host to itself. It contends for CPU, memory, and cache with inference work whose arrival pattern it does not control, and a co-tenant that takes capacity away lowers the load at which the control plane saturates. Saturation is where the two languages separate most sharply in the measurements of Chapter 6. Memory footprint and behaviour past that point are becoming selection criteria in their own right, and neither is settled by the architecture above the code.

The third trend is an industry-wide shift toward memory-safe languages. Large software organisations report that the majority of their serious security vulnerabilities stem from memory-safety errors, and that adopting memory-safe languages measurably reduces them [8, 9, 15, 16]. The case no longer rests on vendor reporting alone: a group spanning academia and industry has argued that memory safety now needs standardised terminology and requirements if it is to be specified and procured at all [17]. This concern has risen to the level of national policy: cybersecurity agencies now urge software manufacturers to publish "memory-safe roadmaps" and to migrate away from memory-unsafe languages such as C and C++ [18, 19]. In the market this subsystem is sold into it has also become a regulatory matter. The EU Cyber Resilience Act places secure-by-design and lifecycle vulnerability-handling obligations on manufacturers of products with digital elements, with the vulnerability-reporting obligations applying from September 2026 and most of the remainder from December 2027 [20]. It names no programming language, and it would be wrong to read it as requiring one. What it changes is that the recurring defect classes of a memory-unsafe language become a compliance exposure as well as an engineering one. Rust in particular has moved from a niche language into operating-system kernels, cloud infrastructure, and increasingly into telecommunications. Production hypervisors such as AWS Firecracker, which underpins its serverless platform, are already written in Rust [21]. Yet the evidence base for Rust's suitability rests largely on general-purpose software and on average-case performance benchmarks. The specific question a telecom vendor must answer, whether Rust can meet the tail-latency and predictability requirements of a RAN control plane, whether it genuinely prevents the defect classes that plague the existing C++ code, and what it costs to adopt it incrementally inside a large C++ codebase, has not been answered with direct, controlled evidence. Providing such evidence for a representative subsystem is the motivation for this work.

Industrial setting. This thesis is carried out at Nokia, one of the small number of vendors that build, maintain, and evolve production RAN software end to end. That market is concentrated in very few hands: the five largest suppliers took 96% of worldwide RAN revenue over the first three quarters of 2025, with concentration by Herfindahl–Hirschman Index at a ten-year high [22, 23]. The subsystem it studies, UE Context Management (UECM), is modelled on a real gNB-CU-CP control-plane component rather than a textbook example.

The gNB-CU-CP is not a minor component. In the 3GPP disaggregated architecture it is the control-plane half of the central unit, hosting RRC and managing the UE context lifecycle [1, 4], under the millisecond-scale procedure budgets the 5G system places on control signalling [5] and at the event rates and connected-device counts a deployed network sustains. Chapter 2 places it in the wider architecture. Because it is written in C++, it inherits both that language's performance and its memory-safety and concurrency hazards. That is precisely where the three trends above converge, and software of this class is shipped, evolved, and operated across live operator networks, so the language-selection decision is a production concern rather than a hypothetical one.

UECM is a deliberate choice of study object within that setting, for the reasons Chapter 3 sets out: it is small enough to reimplement faithfully and reason about in full, yet it carries the properties that make control-plane code hard. The implementation is driven entirely by a public, frozen specification rather than by proprietary code, so the comparison stays reproducible by readers outside Nokia.

A decision with a generational horizon. A language choice in software of this class is not revisited often, and it outlives the generation it was made for. The next one is being specified now: 3GPP has allocated Release 20 to the 6G studies and Release 21 to the normative work, against an ITU calendar that asks for technology proposals in early 2029 and the submitted specifications by mid-2030 [24]. That work explicitly covers migration from and interworking with 5G, so a control plane written for the current generation is maintained alongside the next one rather than retired when it arrives. Nor do the next generation's objectives relax what motivates this comparison. IMT-2030 names security and resilience as one of its four design principles, expects the system to be secure by design, defines resilience as the ability to keep operating correctly during and after a disruptive event, and carries the ultra-reliable low-latency

scenario forward in strengthened form [12]. Freedom from whole classes of defect and predictable behaviour under disturbance are being written into the objectives of the next generation rather than left to implementers.

The policy dates named above fall inside the same window. CISA and the FBI classify the development of new product lines in a memory-unsafe language as a bad practice where the product serves critical infrastructure, a scope mobile-network infrastructure sits squarely inside, and they exempt an existing product from the memory-safe roadmap expectation only when its announced support ends before January 2030 [25]. A vendor that defers the language question until the next generation is specified will not thereby have avoided making it. It will have made it by default, in the incumbent language, for another decade of deployments.

What this thesis contributes to that decision is bounded, and the boundary is worth stating plainly. The measurements here are taken on a subsystem modelled on a current-generation component and evaluated against requirements that are already published. No claim is made about requirements that have not yet been written. What crosses the generational boundary is not a latency figure but the language-level comparison itself: which defect classes a compiler can rule out, what the safety model costs, and what incremental adoption inside a large C++ codebase involves. Those questions have the same answers whichever generation the specification above them names, and they are cheapest to answer before the next codebase is started rather than after.

A concrete failure mode. To make the stakes concrete, consider a mobility storm in which many UEs hand over at once. A single mishandled pointer, a UE context freed on release while an in-flight signalling message still references it, produces a use-after-free. In C++ this compiles cleanly and may pass ordinary testing, only to corrupt an unrelated UE's state or crash the worker thread under precisely the high-concurrency conditions the system exists to handle. The same latent race can equally show up as an unpredictable tail-latency spike instead of an outright crash. In safe Rust the same design does not compile: ownership and borrowing reject the dangling reference at build time. This one scenario captures why the thesis measures both *safety* (which defects are prevented, and when) and *predictability* (tail latency under overload) rather than average throughput alone.

1.2 Problem statement

Two properties of this domain make the language choice consequential. First, manual memory and concurrency management in C++ exposes the software to defects such as use-after-free, double-free, data races, and iterator invalidation, which are silent at compile time and costly to find and fix at telecom scale. Second, what governs whether RAN deadlines are met is not average throughput but worst-case and tail behaviour under load and overload [6], a property that is easy to regress and hard to measure correctly. Rust promises to remove the first class of defect at compile time while claiming performance competitive on the second, but that claim rests mostly on general-purpose benchmarks rather than on stateful, concurrent, latency-critical telecom workloads.

Bringing these threads together, the concrete problem this thesis addresses is the following. Telecom vendors are under growing pressure, both technical and increasingly regulatory, to adopt memory-safe languages, yet for the RAN control plane they lack *direct, controlled* evidence on which to base that decision. It is not established whether a Rust implementation of a stateful, concurrent control-plane subsystem can match modern C++ in *tail latency and predictability under overload* (as opposed to average throughput), whether Rust's compile-time guarantees actually eliminate the specific defect classes that affect the existing C++ code, and what incremental adoption *costs* inside a large C++ codebase. The available evidence is largely general-purpose and average-case [26, 27], leaving these three questions (predictability, prevented-defect scope, and migration cost) open for a representative subsystem. Answering them under controlled, reproducible conditions is the problem this thesis sets out to solve.

1.3 Research questions and hypotheses

The thesis is organised around four research questions, ordered to put predictability and migration ahead of raw average performance:

RQ1 How do Rust and modern C++ compare in latency predictability (median, p99, p99.9 and p99.99 tail latency, and the maximum) for a RAN control-plane workload under increasing load and overload?

RQ2 Which classes of memory-safety and concurrency defects that occur in C++ are

eliminated at compile time in the Rust implementation, and at what stage and cost are the remaining ones detected?

RQ3 What is the overhead, if any, of Rust's safety model (bounds checks, ownership-driven copies, abstraction cost) on throughput, CPU utilisation, and memory behaviour?

RQ4 What are the practical implications (effort, FFI interoperability, and risk) of adopting Rust incrementally within an existing C++ RAN software ecosystem?

The questions are approached with three prior expectations, stated here so that the evaluation can confirm or refute them instead of merely describing results after the fact. **H1:** for this workload the two languages are performance-equivalent in the operationally relevant region below saturation, with any difference confined to the far tail. **H2:** safe Rust prevents at compile time the memory-safety and concurrency defect classes that C++ leaves to best-effort, after-the-fact detection. **H3:** the run-time cost of C++-to-Rust interoperability is negligible relative to the cost of the operations invoked, so that the true cost of incremental adoption is engineering effort rather than performance. H2 is stated so that it can fail. The defect catalogue behind RQ2 spans classes safe Rust is expected to prevent and classes it is expected not to, so the study can locate the boundary of the guarantee instead of only confirming it. These hypotheses are revisited against the evidence in Chapter 7.

1.4 Contributions, results, and limitations

The thesis makes six contributions. Two are artifacts: a reproducible benchmarking framework for telecom control-plane workloads, and a frozen shared specification with two parity-tested implementations of a RAN control-plane subsystem, one in C++ and one in Rust. Three are results. The first is a comparison of latency and resource behaviour that divides at the saturation knee, where the ordering between the two languages reverses. The second is a defect-class taxonomy from controlled fault injection that marks where the compile-time guarantee stops, in both directions. The third is a bound on what a comparison of this shape can attribute to a language at all, obtained by decomposing an end-to-end operation into the work the language performs and the cross-thread handoff around it. The last is a set of engineering and migration guidelines for language selection in cloud-native RAN evolution (Chapter 7). Neither the reversal

nor the attribution bound was anticipated. Both were found while reading results the study had planned to report differently, and Chapter 7 records what the first of them cost H1.

The findings divide three ways. On *safety* (RQ2), every injected memory-safety and data-race defect class is prevented at compile time in safe Rust. The same defects all compile in C++, and each is caught, if at all, only at run time and only under the right sanitiser, or on one class under none of them. Seven boundary classes were chosen deliberately, and neither language prevents them. On two of those the C++ tooling is ahead, and on one the defect that safe Rust rules out returns as soon as the program writes `unsafe`. On *migration* (RQ4), the FFI seam is small and keeps the core free of `unsafe`. Measured against the same operation called natively it costs at most 10.91% of one operation, so the real adoption cost is API design and not run-time overhead. Three costs beyond the seam are measured for the same reason, and two of them come back against the received wisdom: most of the Rust build's extra cost is compiling third-party code and not the compiler's own work, and the binary-size ordering depends on which linkage policy the two toolchains are held to rather than on the languages. Both of these results are final.

On *performance* (RQ1, RQ3) the answer divides twice, and drawing both divisions correctly is where most of the analysis went. The first division separates what the sweep measures from what it can attribute. An end-to-end operation in this design is 0.250% language work and a cross-thread handoff takes the rest, so a matched-pair comparison on that path bounds the design and not the language. The limit holds whichever way such a comparison comes out, and it reaches any study that reports an end-to-end median without measuring the share. Timed apart from the handoff, the operation is 1.6× faster in Rust, which the sweep cannot see.

The second division is by regime. Below saturation the two implementations are equivalent end to end in central behaviour, by a margin no deployment would notice. The paired test does resolve a median difference of 1.3 μs in Rust's favour under both allocators, on an end-to-end round-trip of 70 μs, so the equivalence is practical and not statistical. The far tail in the same regime now resolves on the reported host: the pooled p99.99 of the Rust variants sits below that of the C++ variants at every load where the two separate, and a second bare-metal campaign at another shard count agrees on the direction (Chapter 6). Past saturation the ordering reverses, and where each implementation stops meeting its offered rate is itself a difference: the Rust arms

track to 448 kops/s and the C++ arms to 392. Deeper still, where all four have collapsed, the C++ build sustains 1.7× the throughput of the Rust build in 20/20 interleaved repeats under both allocators, and the Rust build spends 1.8× the CPU on each operation it does complete, which is what rules out the reading that it is simply doing less. On resources the Rust process holds a few MiB more resident memory, again under both allocators, in the same direction and order of magnitude on all three machines measured. How it compares against the cost of the allocator choice is not: the two are comparable on bare metal and the allocator's was an order of magnitude larger on the virtualised host this study used first, so the comparison between them is a property of the machine rather than of the allocators.

Four limitations bound all of this: a synthetic workload, one simplified subsystem, single-author implementation bias, and an allocator footprint whose size moved with the host. Chapter 7 treats each in detail.

The scope is drawn deliberately to protect the internal validity of the language comparison. In scope are the UE Context Management functionality of Chapter 3, the shared-nothing concurrency design, the load sweep to overload, the fault-injection catalogue, and the FFI prototype. Explicitly out of scope are the full gNB system and its remaining control-plane domains, PHY/L2 processing and the data-heavy user plane, real captured traffic traces (as opposed to a spec-justified synthetic workload), managed-language alternatives (excluded on the tail-latency grounds argued in Chapter 2), and production deployment and operational concerns such as upgrade, observability, and multi-tenancy. These exclusions trade external validity for the controlled conditions a fair language comparison needs, and each is revisited as a limitation in Chapter 7.

1.5 Significance and beneficiaries

The results are intended to be directly actionable. For RAN vendors and cloud-native network operators, the thesis supplies controlled evidence on the question that gates any language decision. That question is not "is Rust fast on average?" but "does Rust hold its tail latency and predictability under overload, and what does incremental adoption cost?", answered for a subsystem representative of production control-plane code. For the standards and policy discussion around memory-safe roadmaps [18, 19], it grounds a general mandate in a concrete telecom data point. For the research community, the frozen specification, the parity-tested implementations, the reproducible benchmarking

framework, and the defect-class taxonomy form a reusable baseline for further language and systems studies, and the latency decomposition gives such a study a way to check what its own measurements can attribute. And for practising engineers, the fault catalogue and the migration prototype double as worked examples of what Rust's guarantees do and do not buy in this domain.

2 Background: Systems Languages for Latency-Critical Software

In the NG-RAN architecture the base station (gNB) is split into a central unit and a distributed unit. The central unit is split again into a control plane and a user plane. UE Context Management sits in the control plane, the gNB-CU-CP, and talks to its neighbours over the standardised F1, E1, and NG interfaces [1].

Deadlines are met or missed because of predictability, not average speed. The metrics that matter are the p99 and p99.9 latencies and the jitter around them [6]. They must be measured past the saturation point. They must also be recorded without coordinated omission, that is, without letting a load generator that has fallen behind hide its own slowest requests [28, 29].

C++ offers abstractions that cost nothing at run time, deterministic cleanup through RAII, and no garbage collector. Safety remains the programmer's responsibility [30]. Sanitisers report only the errors that a given test run happens to reach.

Rust has the same run-time model and also no garbage collector. It checks memory safety and freedom from data races at compile time, using ownership, borrowing, and thread-safety traits such as `Send` [10, 31]. Code that needs to step outside those rules must be marked `unsafe`. That keeps such code small and easy to find.

The comparison is C++ against Rust. Garbage-collected languages are left out because their pauses are incompatible with the latency targets. The concurrency model is held fixed in both implementations. The C ABI is treated as the realistic adoption path. No earlier study isolates the language this way for a stateful, concurrent subsystem [32, 33].

3 Problem Context: UE Context Management and Predictability

UE Context Management owns the lifecycle of one context per connected device. Each context moves through four states, Idle, Connected, Reconfiguring, and Released, driven by a small set of lifecycle operations. An operation that is illegal in the current state returns a typed error. It is not carried out.

The subsystem was chosen because it is representative and still small enough to keep under control. It has mutable state per device, a strict lifecycle, heavy concurrency, and hard latency targets [5, 34]. It is still simple enough to specify precisely and to test for identical behaviour in two languages.

Seven defect classes fall inside Rust's guarantee. Each has a natural form in this subsystem: use-after-free, double-free, iterator invalidation, data race, unguarded shared mutation, use-after-move, and a thread-unsafe handle shared between workers. The guarantee rests on aliasing control and data-race freedom [31]. The catalogue is this study's own.

Seven further classes are included on purpose from outside that guarantee: a lock-order deadlock, a lost update, a leak through a reference cycle, an integer overflow in a release build, the blast radius of a failed shard worker, a double release across the C-ABI seam, and a lock guard that is never dropped. They keep the study from confirming a foregone conclusion. They show where the guarantee stops. Two of them return the opposite of the expected result. The C++ tooling reports what Rust's does not.

Scale is what makes the tail matter. One procedure triggers many operations. One site serves many devices. A p99.9 measured on a single operation becomes a steady rate of degraded procedures in the field [6]. That is why the load sweep is pushed past the point where the service starts to fall behind.

4 Research Methodology

The approach is empirical and constructive. Instead of comparing two systems that already exist and differ in many ways, the study builds a matched pair of implementations from one frozen specification. The language is then the only systematic difference between them. Both use an identical thread-per-shard concurrency model. That structuring itself changes tail latency [35].

RQ1 and RQ3 are answered with an open-loop load sweep from light load into overload on pinned cores. Open-loop means the generator keeps to its send schedule instead of waiting for replies. Latency is recorded in identically configured HDR histograms [29]. Resource use is sampled through the operating system. The reported sweep runs on a dedicated AMD EPYC 7443, simultaneous multithreading off, frequency governor fixed at performance, with `nohz_full` on the pinned cores and no hypervisor. That host resolves the overload divergence, the resource comparison, and the far tail below saturation. The same design was first measured on a Intel(R) Xeon(R) CPU E5-2680 v4 guest (kvm) that could not resolve the far tail: there the widest interval on one variant's p99 exceeded the spread between all four by a factor of five, so no ordering could be read however many repeats were run. A third sweep on a second bare-metal AMD EPYC 7443P uses a different shard count, load grid, repeat count and toolchain, so it tests whether the findings survive a change of design rather than a change of machine.

RQ2 is answered by controlled fault injection [36]. A fixed catalogue of defects is written in both languages. The expected outcome of each one is recorded in advance. A surprise then shows up as a discrepancy, not as something explained away afterwards.

RQ4 is answered by a working prototype in which C++ drives the Rust core through a foreign-function interface. Cross-language memory-management defects concentrate at that seam [37]. It yields three measurements: how large the seam is, how much `unsafe` code it needs, and what one call across it costs.

Fairness is the central experimental control. The specification is frozen. Allocator and optimisation settings are matched. Every point where the two languages had to differ is written down in a forced-idiom log. Reporting follows the guidance that a single figure invites conclusions run-to-run variation does not support [38]. Medians come with

nonparametric bootstrap confidence intervals [39]. Exact paired permutation tests are corrected for multiple comparisons by the Holm procedure [40]. All data is synthetic, so no data-protection concerns arise.

5 Design and Implementation

Nothing is implemented until the specification is frozen. It fixes the public API, the UE state machine, the data structures and their algorithmic strategy, the locking and sharding granularity, and the concurrency model. Both implementations conform to it. The comparison then measures the language, not a difference of design or of skill. The specification is itself a deliverable. It is the study's main control against implementation bias.

One concurrency model is used on both sides, shared-nothing and thread-per-shard. That structuring is known to change tail latency by itself [35]. The identifier space is partitioned into shards. Each shard is owned by a single worker thread that alone reads or mutates it, so no lock guards context state. Callers submit a request to the owning shard's bounded queue and wait on a single-use completion handle. The queue blocks when it is full. That is deliberate. A drop policy would hide overload, and this study needs overload to appear as latency. The only shared mutable state either version permits is one atomic counter. No control flow depends on its value.

Fairness is enforced below the design as well as in it. Both builds link the same `jemalloc` and keep a system-allocator build as a control. Both compile at matched optimisation. Both record latency through one HDR histogram algorithm configured identically [29]. Hashing is pinned on both sides, SplitMix64 for shard assignment and FNV-1a inside the map. C++'s default hash of an integer is typically the identity function. Rust's is cryptographically strong. Left as they came, the two standard libraries would have been the measurement.

Where the languages cannot satisfy a requirement the same way, the divergence is written into a forced-idiom log and then measured. Rust takes its bounded blocking queue from `sync_channel`. C++ through C++23 has no such primitive. It assembles one from a mutex and two condition variables. C++ has no payload-carrying enumeration in this idiom either. A request becomes a tagged struct holding every argument field any operation might need, 160 bytes against Rust's 96. The caller answers through a `variant` it has to unwrap. The net result is a Rust core 18% longer in code lines whose total cyclomatic complexity is 15% lower [41]. The branchiest function in either core is the C++ worker loop that dispatches that `variant`. The Rust library contains no

`unsafe` at all.

Parity is tested and not assumed. Language-neutral vectors run in both implementations and their transcripts are diffed operation by operation. A cross-diff cannot tell “both correct” from “both wrong in the same way”. A third implementation in Python acts as an independent oracle. It has to reproduce all 223 hand-derived expectations before it may generate any of its own. A campaign of roughly 793 000 generated operations found no divergence. The transition matrix is enumerated exhaustively instead of sampled. The C++ side runs under AddressSanitizer, ThreadSanitizer and UndefinedBehaviorSanitizer. The Rust side runs under Miri. Line coverage is reported. A clean sanitiser result is therefore bounded by the code that actually ran.

6 Experimental Setup and Evaluation

The workload is synthetic and spec-justified. A deterministic driver walks each UE through the connection lifecycle the 3GPP specifications define. Its draw order is pinned, so the per-operation-kind counts come out identical in both languages for a given seed. That doubles as a parity signal. Each sweep point is repeated 20 times. The four language and allocator variants are interleaved inside every repeat, so thermal or background drift falls on all of them alike. Every point is a median with a bootstrap 95% confidence interval [38, 39]. The representative operating point is fixed at 56 kops/s and not derived. The rule this study began with, the busiest swept load holding p99 under 5 ms, located the virtualised host's noise floor and on a quiet host climbs until it collapses onto the saturation knee, so it is kept as a diagnostic only. The measured throughput plateau is 392 kops/s, the lowest of the four, reached at an offered 392 kops/s. All of it runs on a dedicated AMD EPYC 7443 pinned to cores 2–17. The frequency governor is fixed at performance with boost disabled. The kernel runs tickless on those cores. There is no hypervisor. Isolating the cores with `isolcpus` is omitted on purpose, because it would collapse the pinned set onto one core. The same design was first measured on a Intel(R) Xeon(R) CPU E5-2680 v4 guest that could not resolve the far tail. A second bare-metal host at a different shard count confirms that the directions survive a change of design.

Below saturation the four variants sit within 2 μs of one another at the median, 2.1%. The paired test resolves a difference of 1.3 μs in Rust's favour under both allocators. Higher up the distribution the ordering can now be read. The widest interval on a single variant's own p99 spans 1 μs against 2 μs of spread between all four, so the uncertainty about one is smaller than the gap between them. On the virtualised host the same two quantities were 1480 μs against 293 μs, the wrong way round. The far tail resolves here too, from the repeats' histograms pooled into 3 360 051 to 3 360 084 operations per variant, and both Rust variants sit below both of the others by up to 87 μs. A second bare-metal host at another shard count agrees, running 147–228 μs for the C++ variants against 88–115 μs for the Rust ones, without overlap. A second limit is structural. No host would fix it. An end-to-end operation is 0.250% the work

the language performs. The rest is a cross-thread handoff charged to the operating system [42]. This sweep cannot bound a language effect in either direction. Measured on its own the bare operation is 1.6× faster in Rust. The likely cause is the standard hash map's layout, not anything about safety.

Past saturation the languages are not equivalent, and they part company twice. They stop meeting the offered rate at different loads: the Rust arms hold to 448 kops/s and the C++ arms to 392, so at 448 kops/s Rust still serves 448 kops/s where C++ has collapsed to 162. That rung is described and not tested, because the operating point was found after the data was in hand. Deeper, at 784 kops/s offered, the ordering reverses: C++ sustains 147 kops/s where Rust sustains 84, a factor of 1.7, in 20/20 repeats under both allocators with the Holm-corrected p at the floor of the whole test family. The slower variant is not simply doing less work. It draws 1.8 times the CPU per completed operation, which is the signature of effort spent without completing anything. Isolating the bounded queue and the completion handle on their own does not reproduce that ordering at significance, so the mechanism sits in the wider handoff path. This is the largest language effect in the tested family. A comparison that stopped at nominal load would have concluded the opposite.

Safety is measured by injecting 14 defects. Seven come from inside the region Rust claims to govern. Seven were chosen because safe Rust is expected *not* to prevent them [36]. Every one of the first seven is a compile error in Rust. It cannot be written at all. In C++ each is valid code. The defect appears only if a test drives it, and no single sanitiser covers them. The use-after-move is the case where no sanitiser reports anything: a moved-from object is valid but unspecified, so there is nothing to detect and the identity is simply lost. All seven boundary cases compile in safe Rust and misbehave. On two of them the C++ tooling is the one that reports. LeakSanitizer flags the reference cycle that Rust leaks in silence. UndefinedBehaviorSanitizer flags the overflow that Rust defines to wrap. ThreadSanitizer catches the lock-order inversion on some runs and not others, at a rate that is itself unstable. It builds its lock-order graph from acquisitions that succeed. A run whose first inversion blocks never closes the cycle. Two Rust model checkers do report both original boundary defects, but only after each was re-imported against the checker's own primitives and shrunk to model size [43]. Miri reports the seam double release, the one class that safe Rust rejects and unsafe Rust does not, but it interprets Rust and cannot execute the C++ host the defect ships behind. That half of the boundary is caught at test time, and for the

concurrency cases only after a rewrite.

Resource use separates the variants where latency could not. Two effects of comparable size sit in the resident set. The Rust build costs 1.4–2.5 MiB more peak resident set than the C++ build under either allocator. Linking `jemalloc` at all costs 1.5–2.4 MiB in either language. Both are real. The language effect keeps its direction and order of magnitude on all three machines measured. The allocator's was an order of magnitude larger on the virtualised host this study used first, so their ratio is a property of the machine. The language difference is a fixed cost, not a per-context one, and the quiet host locates it. `jemalloc`'s own accounting there puts +2.07 MiB more in arena bookkeeping and −0.16 MiB *less* in live allocation, and its resident bytes are −1.92 MiB lower while the process peak is +1.74 MiB higher. So the footprint sits outside the allocator, in the runtime a Rust process carries before it allocates. Counters at the operation scope explain the timing result instead: the Rust build retires 11% fewer instructions in 15% fewer cycles. CPU inverts with the regime. It is marginally lower for Rust while the service copes and much higher per completed operation once it does not. The migration seam is small on every axis measured: 11 C entry points in 231 lines of Rust. All raw-pointer work is confined to 9 functions. The core is left free of `unsafe`. No cost is detected against the same operation called natively. That bounds any per-operation tax at 10.91%. Three adoption costs beyond the seam were measured as well. Two of them contradict the received objection. 54% of the Rust clean build is third-party code. The project's own source compiles in 0.8 times the CPU `g++` needs. The 6.8× binary-size gap is a linkage policy that reverses when the policy is held fixed. The compared component resolves 0 crates and contains 0 `unsafe` sites.

7 Discussion

RQ1's answer divides at saturation. Reporting either half on its own would misrepresent it. Below the knee the two languages are equivalent in central behaviour by a margin no deployment would notice. That is a result about services of this shape. The far tail in the same regime now resolves on the reported host, in Rust's favour. On the virtualised host that the study used first, that percentile could not be ordered at all. Past the knee they diverge in both directions: the Rust arms reach a higher knee, and once both have collapsed the C++ arms sustain 1.7× the throughput. Which of those matters depends on whether a deployment expects to be driven past every arm's knee. The closest prior work measures this quantity for 5G control-plane procedures. It finds the same shape and traces it to stackless `async/await` [44]. That attribution is accepted here. The shape appeared with no asynchronous runtime on either side and the concurrency model held fixed. A runtime cannot be the only place such an effect originates. The prediction registered in advance also named where to look first, bounds and overflow checking. That part of it was wrong. Recording the miss is worth more to the next study than quietly substituting the explanation that survived.

On safety the difference is one of kind. The boundary is reported as a first-class result, not as a caveat. A compiler that refuses to build a program rules the defect out of every execution. A sanitiser rules it out only of the executions an instrumented test happens to take. What is absolute there is the execution coverage, not the breadth of the catalogue. Rust reasons about aliasing and not about acquisition order. A `Mutex` guard whose lifetime the borrow checker tracks perfectly says nothing about whether two threads take their locks in a compatible order [45]. The lost update escapes ThreadSanitizer for the same reason it escapes the borrow checker. Where every access is correctly synchronised, there is no unsynchronised access to find. Adopting Rust retires one category of concurrency defect and leaves untouched the category that fails silently. A migration plan reading "memory-safe" as "concurrency-safe" would mis-budget its review effort. One case reaches past the injected programs and narrows the credit due on both sides. A specification gap let an operation be submitted outside the service's running window. It survived every test, every parity vector and all three sanitisers because nothing ever called that path. That is the weakness of detection conditional on coverage. What turned undefined behaviour into a diagnosable failure

on the Rust side was an ordinary bounds check, not a proof. The property worth budgeting for is “checked by default”, not “ruled out at compile time”. The root cause belongs to the method. A prohibition stated without a mechanism behind it leaves each implementation to fail in its own idiom.

RQ3 splits by resource and the splits do not point the same way. RQ4 comes out cheap in the machine and expensive in the people. The memory penalty reproduces under both allocators and on a second machine with a different compiler. It is credible beyond its p-value. Peak resident set is a run-level maximum insensitive to the jitter that destroys a p99. It is a few MiB of fixed cost, and sized against the allocator’s own effect the two are of the same order on both bare-metal hosts, interleaved on the reported one and with the allocator ahead on the other. On the virtualised host the allocator’s was an order of magnitude larger. The language effect travels and the ratio does not. The quiet host also locates the cost. `jemalloc`’s own accounting puts it *outside* the allocator, because the Rust build holds less live data and fewer resident bytes there and still peaks +1.74 MiB higher. What a Rust process carries before it allocates is the standard library and the runtime. Which of its pages hold the difference is not attributed to a call site. One close study reports the opposite sign, with Rust lowest and the gap widening as concurrency rises [32]. The two are compatible. Their C++ runs on Boost.Fibers, which allocates a stack per fiber. Their Rust runs on Tokio, where a task is a small heap-allocated future. What they measured is the per-context cost of two concurrency runtimes. Two further studies agree with the direction found here [46, 47]. On migration the dominant cost is human [48, 49]. Confining `unsafe` to the seam bounds what has to be reviewed, not what can be corrupted. Host and component share one address space [50, 51]. The build and footprint axes point the same way as the seam. An organisation worried about either should audit its dependency budget before blaming the compiler. The one axis where C++ leads outright is the edit-compile loop for changes that stay inside a translation unit.

The three hypotheses were committed before any measurement. Stating their disposition is what separates a test from a description. H1 is supported below saturation and refuted above it. It is not in the direction its wording anticipated. The largest difference appeared in overload, which H1 did not consider. The far tail H1 did name is half right: the reported campaign now resolves it, in Rust’s favour, and a second bare-metal host at another shard count agrees on the direction. H1 was right about where to look and wrong that it was the only place. It was also not well posed. “Performance-equivalent”

reads as one quantity and names at least three. H2 holds without exception for the seven injected classes of its kind. It fails in the looser reading its wording invites. It is accepted for memory safety and data-race freedom, rejected for concurrency correctness at large, and it is a claim about *safe* Rust only: the seam case shows the same class returning inside `unsafe`. H3 is supported by the bound on a cost the measurement could have missed, not by the failure to detect one. Three threats stay load-bearing behind all of it. One author wrote both implementations. The parity suite bounds behaviour and not performance [33]. The end-to-end instrument measures the design faithfully and the language barely at all. The overload divergence is replicated here with its mechanism narrowed and not closed, and no peer-reviewed study reports the same reversal.

The guidelines are the practical form of all this. Each carries the limit of the finding behind it. Choose a first component for the narrowness and the scalarity of its interface, not for its size. The redesign of a rich interface is the schedule risk. The boundary itself is not. Keep the C ABI in its own crate and the core free of `unsafe`. That makes the reviewable surface a countable thing [52]. Leave the concurrency review budget where it is. Prefer a shared-nothing structure in either language. The strongest concurrency result here belongs to the design and to neither compiler. Plan the learning curve as a training cost and instrument it. The second component can then be scheduled on measured effort. Measure the component as well as the round-trip. Sweep past the point where the service stops coping. That is the guideline this study would most like to have followed from the start.

8 Conclusion and Future Work

The thesis compared modern C++ and Rust on a UE Context Management service modelled on a real gNB-CU-CP component. It looked at four dimensions: tail-latency predictability, compile-time defect prevention, safety-model overhead, and incremental-adoption cost. Both implementations were built against one frozen specification and driven along identical code paths. That is what lets a language effect be told apart from a difference of design or of skill.

On safety the difference is one of kind and it has a definite edge. The edge stops where the catalogue says it does. Safe Rust rejects all seven injected memory-safety and data-race classes at compile time. Hazards that C++ can only hope to catch with instrumented tests become programs that cannot be written. All seven boundary classes compile and misbehave in safe Rust as they do in C++. On two of them the C++ tooling reports what Rust's does not. Stated precisely, Rust eliminates data races and aliasing errors. It does not eliminate race conditions, lock-ordering errors, leaks, wrapping arithmetic or the blast radius of a failed worker, and it eliminates nothing inside an `unsafe` block.

On performance the evidence divides twice before it divides by resource. Getting both divisions right was this study's most consequential correction to itself. It divides first by what is being measured. An end-to-end operation here is 0.250% language. The rest is an operating-system handoff. An end-to-end null bounds nothing about either compiler. The same operation measured apart is 1.6× faster in Rust. It divides second by whether the service is coping. Below saturation the two are equivalent at the median for any purpose a deployment would care about. The paired test does resolve 1.3 μs in Rust's favour, so that equivalence is practical and not statistical. Their far tail resolves in Rust's favour on the reported host, which a virtualised host could not settle. Past saturation the Rust arms hold their offered rate one rung further, and beyond that C++ sustains 1.7× the throughput of Rust, which spends 1.8× the CPU on each operation it completes. On memory the Rust build carries a few MiB more fixed footprint under both allocators, in the same direction and order of magnitude on all three machines measured. The allocator choice costs about as much on both bare-metal hosts, and an order of magnitude more on the virtualised one this study used first.

What follows is a narrow claim, narrower than this thesis expected to make. An unmodified Rust core can be driven from C++ across a thin seam. The cost on a real operation is bounded at 10.91%. All `unsafe` is confined to the seam. The core is verified free of it. For stateful, concurrent, partitionable control-plane services of this kind, and at nominal load, the choice between the two languages is not a performance decision. It is a decision about which classes of defect an organisation wants to make unwriteable, and about whether it will pay the engineering and learning cost of getting them. Around and past saturation it becomes a performance decision again, and which way it goes depends on where the service is expected to sit: the Rust build meets its offered rate a rung further up, and deeper into overload the C++ build sustains more of what it is given. What the thesis adds is an instrument, not a verdict: a frozen specification, a parity-tested pair of implementations, a measurement framework that reaches past the saturation knee, a decomposition that says how much of what it measures the language is answerable for, and a defect catalogue that maps where the guarantee stops.

Future work answers the limitations one at a time. The immediate priority needs no new machine: vary the transparent-hugepage policy on one host with everything else held fixed. All three hosts agree that the Rust build carries the larger footprint. They disagree about how that compares against the cost of the allocator, which the virtualised host put an order of magnitude higher and neither bare-metal host does. The hugepage policy is the candidate this study can name but not test, because it differed between the hosts and only the system-allocator arm inherits it. Beyond that, replaying anonymised production traces would validate the operation mix. A subsystem with genuinely shared mutable state would exercise the two languages differently than a shared-nothing design does. Evaluating Rust async runtimes against the thread-per-shard model would separate the runtime from the language in the tail result [44]. Measuring what in-process isolation of the two heaps costs would price what protecting an `unsafe`-free core is worth [50]. A longer case study tracking defect density and review effort during an incremental adoption is what would settle the human cost this study can only name.

Statement on the Use of AI Tools

Tool. Anthropic's Claude Opus 5, used through the Cursor development environment, is the only generative AI system used in preparing this thesis, and it was used throughout, from June 2026 until submission. It is named neither as an author, which University of Helsinki policy forbids, nor as a source, which is the author's own choice.

What the assistance covered. It was extensive. The model drafted and revised the running prose and proposed the order in which the arguments are made. It wrote and refactored both implementations of the UE Context Management service, the load generator, the fault-injection catalogue, the interoperability prototype, the analysis code behind the bootstrap intervals and the paired permutation tests, and the figure-generating, build and LaTeX sources. It also suggested candidate literature. The abstract is the one part it must not touch: University of Helsinki policy never permits a language model in a maturity test, and in this programme the maturity test is the abstract. In this draft it has not yet been rewritten unaided, and this statement will say so until it has been.

What the model did not settle. The research problem, the four research questions, the three hypotheses, and the control on which the study's value rests are the author's. That control is one frozen language-neutral specification and one concurrency model, so language remains the only systematic difference between the two implementations. The author also chose to carry defect classes from outside Rust's compile-time guarantee, which is what keeps RQ2 falsifiable. Every measurement was run by the author, on the machines each result names, and the quantities the thesis quotes reach the page as macros regenerated from the raw logs rather than as figures typed into a paragraph. The readings are the author's too, including the restraints the evidence imposes: a sweep dominated by cross-thread handoff cannot bound an effect of the language, an unresolved comparison is not a demonstration of equivalence, and an operating point noticed after the data was in hand is described rather than tested.

How the output was checked. Model output was treated as a draft to be falsified. Every bibliography entry was resolved against Crossref, DataCite, or the issuing body. Most were then graded by how far the claim made of it could be traced: to the page or clause itself, to a publisher-deposited record carrying it, or no further than confirmed

metadata behind a paywall. The audit records that grade per entry, so the entries whose supporting passage was never opened are listed rather than absorbed, and it records which entries were added after the grading sweep and carry verified metadata only. It found four passages that overstated or misplaced their source, one a quotation absent from the work it was attributed to. All four were corrected, and the audit is kept beside the artefacts. Code was checked by running it, against a conformance suite whose transcripts are diffed line by line and a fault catalogue that fixes each expected outcome before the defect is injected.

What the author took from it. The model is dependable at mechanical work, at transposing an idiom between two languages or keeping a build honest. It is undependable in one predictable way: it will supply a plausible citation for a claim and a confident sentence where the data supports a hedge. Its fluency is not evidence. The effort saved in drafting is spent again in checking, and the defensible parts of this thesis are the parts checked against a source, a specification, or a measurement.

Responsibility. The author is responsible for the whole of this thesis. Where it is wrong, the error is the author's.

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